

APA Report Writing & Your Research Project

PS50008A Week 16 | Lecture

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Learning Outcomes

By the end of this lecture you will be able to:

- Identify the sections of an APA-style lab report and their purpose
- Understand how a Method section is structured (using your Research Plan as an example)
- Apply APA writing conventions (tense, person, statistical notation)
- Understand the Research Report and your group project

Welcome Back

After Reading Week

- Welcome back from Reading Week
- Hopefully you've been working on your **Research Plan**
- Today: APA report format, how to write a Method section, and your group project

 **Research Plan Due This Friday**

Friday 27 February, 12 noon — Submit via Learn.gold

[View the full assessment brief](#)

Today's Plan

Part 1: The APA Lab Report — what goes where and why

Part 2: Writing a Method section — using your Research Plan as an example

Part 3: APA writing conventions — the rules of the game

Part 4: Your Research Report — a new study with your group

Part 1: The APA Lab Report

What Goes Where and Why

Why Does Format Matter?

- Psychology uses a **standardised format** for reporting research
- Readers know exactly where to find information
- Allows critical evaluation of methods and findings
- You will use this format for your **Research Report** (due 1 April)

APA Format: The publication style of the American Psychological Association. Used worldwide in psychology for journal articles, lab reports, and dissertations.

The Sections of a Lab Report

Every APA lab report follows the same structure:

- 1. Title Page**
- 2. Abstract**
- 3. Introduction**
- 4. Method**
- 5. Results**
- 6. Discussion**
- 7. References**

The Hourglass Shape

The APA Report Hourglass: Structuring Your Research



The hourglass

Details

Introduction — Broad to narrow

- Start with the big picture
- Narrow to your specific study
- End with your hypothesis

Method & Results — The narrow middle

- Precise and specific
- Exactly what you did and found

Discussion — Narrow to broad

When Will You Write Each Section?

Section	What it does	When you'll write it
Title Page	Identifies the study	Week 20 onwards
Abstract	~150-word summary	Write last
Introduction	Background + hypothesis	Weeks 17-18
Method	What you did	Weeks 17-18
Results	What you found	Week 19-20
Discussion	What it means	Week 20 onwards
References	Source list	Throughout

Let's Walk Through Each Section

Section 1: Title Page

Purpose: Identify the study, the author, and the institution.

- **Title:** Concise and informative — include your key variables
- **Your name** and student number
- **Module code:** PS50008A

Good title: “The Effect of Word Type on Free Recall Performance”

Bad title: “My Development Environment”

Section 2: Abstract

Purpose: A brief summary of the entire study (~150 words). Written **last**.

- One or two sentences on **background/rationale**
- One sentence on **method** (design, participants, task)
- One or two sentences on **key results** (with statistics)
- One sentence on **conclusion/implications**

Pro Tip

Write the abstract after everything else. It's a summary, not a preview.

Section 3: Introduction

Purpose: Provide background, establish rationale, state your hypothesis.

The funnel structure:

1. **Broad context** — What is the general topic area?
2. **Key research** — What have other researchers found?
3. **Gap or question** — What hasn't been addressed?
4. **Your study** — What are you investigating and why?
5. **Hypothesis** — Your specific, testable prediction

Introduction: What NOT to Do

Which of these is a problem in an Introduction?

- A. Starting with a dictionary definition
- B. Citing relevant research to build an argument
- C. Including your results
- D. Both A and C

 **Warning**

Answer: D — Don't start with "The dictionary defines..." and never reveal your results in the Introduction. Build a logical argument from the literature.

Section 4: Method

Purpose: Describe what you did in enough detail that someone could **replicate** your study.



Sound Familiar?

The Method section has four subsections — the same ones you’ve been writing in your Research Plan. Let’s use your Research Plan as a worked example.

Section 5: Results

Purpose: Report what you found — descriptive and inferential statistics.

- **Descriptive statistics** — means, SDs (often in a table)
- **Inferential test** — the t-test result with full APA notation
- **Effect size** — Cohen's d with 95% confidence interval
- **Brief verbal description** — what the numbers mean in words

 **Note**

Section 6: Discussion

Purpose: Interpret your findings, acknowledge limitations, suggest future directions.

1. **Restate key findings** (in words, not statistics)
2. **Interpret** — what do the results mean?
3. **Relate to literature** — support or contradict previous research?
4. **Limitations** — what could have been done differently?
5. **Future directions** — what should researchers do next?
6. **Conclusion** — take-home message

Section 7: References

Purpose: Full reference list in APA format for every source cited.

Journal article format:

Walker, I., & Hulme, C. (1999). Concrete words are easier to recall than abstract words: Evidence for a semantic contribution to short-term serial recall. *Journal of Experimental Psychology: Learning, Memory, and Cognition*, 25(5), 1256–1271.



Part 2: Writing a Method Section

Your Research Plan as a Worked Example

The Key Insight

! Your Research Plan Practises Method Writing

The Research Plan you're submitting this Friday is a **standalone assessment** on its own topic. But the skills are identical — it's structured exactly like a Method section.

When you write your Research Report later (on a **different** topic, with your group), you'll use the same structure. Let's walk through it now.

Method Section Structure

A Method section needs...	In your Research Plan...	In your Research Report...
Hypothesis	Your chosen topic	Your group project topic
Design + justification	Design subsection	Design subsection
Who takes part	Participants subsection	Participants subsection
What you use	Materials subsection	Materials subsection

Method Subsection 1: Design

What to include:

- Type of design (between-subjects or within-subjects)
- Independent variable and its levels
- Dependent variable and how it's measured

Weak:

“We used a between-subjects design.”

Strong:

“A between-subjects design was used. The independent variable was word type with two levels: concrete words and abstract words. The dependent variable was the number of words correctly recalled out of 15.”

Method Subsection 2: Participants

What to include:

- Total number (and per condition if between-subjects)
- Recruitment method
- Key demographics (age range, mean age, gender)
- Inclusion/exclusion criteria

Good example:

“Twenty participants (15 female, 5 male; $M_{\text{age}} = 21.3$, $SD = 2.1$) were recruited via opportunity sampling from the

Method Subsection 3: Materials

What to include:

- Stimuli (word lists, images, questionnaires)
- How they were created or sourced
- Key properties (e.g., word frequency, length)
- Equipment used (if relevant)

Good example:

“Two word lists were constructed, each containing 15 words. The concrete list contained words referring to

Method Subsection 4: Procedure

What to include:

- Chronological account of what happened
- What participants experienced step by step
- Timing of each phase
- Standardised instructions (summarised)
- Ethical safeguards (consent, debrief)

Good example:

“Participants were tested individually. After providing

Common Method Mistakes

- Too vague: “Participants did a memory test” — what kind? How long? How scored?
- Including results: Method describes what you *did*, not what you *found*
- Missing justification: State your design AND explain *why* you chose it
- Wrong tense: Method uses **past tense** (“participants were asked...”)
- Forgetting ethics: Always mention consent and debriefing

What Makes a Good Research Plan?

Your Research Plan will be assessed on:

- Clarity and appropriateness of hypothesis
- Justification of design choices
- Feasibility and detail of procedure
- Appropriate selection and justification of statistical test
- Overall coherence and scientific reasoning



Tip

Part 3: APA Writing Conventions

The Rules of the Game

Tense

Past tense — for what was done

- “Participants **were** randomly allocated...”
- “The study **used** a between-subjects design...”
- “Results **showed** a significant difference...”

Present tense — for established facts

- “Research **suggests** that concrete words...”
- “Dual coding theory **proposes** that...”
- “The concreteness effect **is** well-documented...”

Person and Voice

- **Third person** preferred in most sections
 - “Participants were asked to...” (*not “I asked participants to...”*)
 - “The study aimed to...” (*not “We aimed to...”*)
- **Passive voice** is acceptable in Method and Results
 - “Words were presented for two minutes”
- **Active voice** for clarity when describing others’ work
 - “Walker and Hulme (1999) found that...”

Statistical Notation

Key rules:

- **Italicise** statistical symbols: t , F , r , p , M , SD , d , n , N
- **Leading zero** for statistics that CAN exceed 1: $M = 0.45$
- **No leading zero** for statistics that CANNOT exceed 1: $p = .023$, $r = .72$

t-test result in APA format:

$t(18) = 2.45$, $p = .025$, $d = 0.87$, 95% CI [0.12, 1.61]

Reporting a t-test: Step by Step

Step 1: Descriptives

“The concrete word group recalled more words ($M = 11.2$, $SD = 2.4$) than the abstract word group ($M = 8.7$, $SD = 2.1$).”

Step 2: Inferential test

“An independent-samples t-test revealed a significant difference, $t(18) = 2.48$, $p = .023$.”

Step 3: Effect size

“The effect size was medium to large, $d = 1.11$, $95\% CI [0.47, 1.75]$, $p < .001$.”

The Complete Results Paragraph

“Participants in the concrete word condition recalled significantly more words ($M = 11.2$, $SD = 2.4$) than those in the abstract word condition ($M = 8.7$, $SD = 2.1$). An independent-samples t-test confirmed this difference was statistically significant, $t(18) = 2.48$, $p = .023$, $d = 1.11$, 95% CI [0.17, 2.03]. This suggests that word concreteness has a large effect on free recall performance.”

Note

You don't need to write results yet — but this is what you're building toward.

Quick Reference: APA Checklist

Before you submit anything, check:

- ☐ Past tense in Method and Results?
- ☐ Third person throughout?
- ☐ Statistical symbols italicised?
- ☐ No leading zero before p and r ?
- ☐ Every claim supported by a citation or data?
- ☐ Reference list matches in-text citations?

Part 4: Your Research Report

A New Study With Your Group

Two Assessments, Two Studies

! Research Plan ≠ Research Report

These are **separate assessments** on **different topics**.

- **Research Plan** (due this Friday) — your chosen topic (font/hydration/eye contact)
- **Research Report** (due 1 April) — your **group project** topic (assigned in Thursday's lab)

The Research Plan practises the skills. The Research Report applies them to real data you collect as a group.

Your Research Report

Assessment 4: Research Report

- **Due:** mid-late April
- **Word count:** 2,500 words
- **Format:** Individual APA-style lab report
- **Weight:** 40% of module mark (double-weighted)
- **Based on:** Your group project data (a **different** study from your Research Plan)

[View the full assessment brief](#)

How It Works

1. **Thursday's lab:** Form groups (3–4 students), receive your project topic
2. **Weeks 17–18:** Design your study, find literature, develop methodology
3. **Week 19:** Collect data as a group
4. **Week 20:** Analyse data, begin writing
5. **Easter:** Write your individual Research Report
6. **mid-late April:** Submit

Individual Report, Group Data

Important

While data comes from your group project, the Research Report is an **individual** assessment. Each group member writes their own report independently.

- **Same data**, different reports
- Your Introduction, interpretation, and evaluation should be your own
- Do NOT copy from group members
- Do NOT share written drafts

The Timeline

When	What happens	What you'll write
Wk 16 (now)	Form groups, receive topic, begin lit review	—
Wk 17	Finalise methodology and design	Introduction drafting
Wk 18	Develop procedure and materials	Method section
Wk 19	Collect data	Results section

Your Research Project

Group Formation & What Happens Next

Thursday's Lab

You **MUST** Attend Thursday's Lab

This is where you **form your project groups** (3-4 students).

If you do not attend and have not signalled your intent to participate, you will be **allocated to a group on Monday of Week 17.**

What Happens in the Lab

1. **Form groups** — find 2-3 other people to work with
2. Register your group
3. **Identify your project topic** — one topic per group
4. **Begin your literature review** — search PsycINFO and Google Scholar
5. **Start generating a hypothesis** — based on what you find
6. **Begin thinking about design** — how will you test it?

Project Timeline

Week	Group milestone
16 (now)	Form groups, begin literature review
17	Finalise methodology and design
18	Develop procedure and materials, submit documents
19	Collect data, upload data
20	Receive results, begin write-up
Easter	Individual report writing
1 April	Research Report due

Summary

Key Takeaways

- APA reports follow a **standard structure**: Title, Abstract, Introduction, Method, Results, Discussion, References
- Your Research Plan **practises Method writing** — the same structure applies to your Research Report (on a different topic)
- Use **past tense** for Method/Results, **present tense** for established findings
- **Italicise** statistical symbols; no leading zero for p and r
- Your **Research Report** is a new study with your group — builds week by week

This Week's Priorities

Wednesday (today): Understand APA format and Method section writing

Thursday (lab): Form your project group and begin literature review for your Research Report

Friday 12 noon: Submit your Research Plan via Learn.gold

Questions?

Questions?

Research Plan due Friday 27 February, 12 noon

Bence will see you in the lab on Thursday!